In this point of view, acceptance of criticism is integral to norms of good behaviour in liberal democracy, and is a noble thing.

Respecting and valuing criticism is not just about fair play. As the Marathi aphorism by Sant Tukaram at the beginning of the chapter says, it is also about the self-interest of the policymaker. As our information and wisdom are always limited, it is useful to have people in our midst, who will identify mistakes in our reasoning.

Neuroscientists have described a phenomenon called ‘the power paradox’: persons who possess power appear to become more impulsive, less risk-aware, and less adept at seeing things from other people’s point of view. [1] This makes mistakes more likely. Encouraging and respecting criticism is the key path to avoiding hubris.

Another dimension of the gains from nurturing criticism is related to the idea of crossing the river by feeling the stones, using feedback loops. The best way to make progress is to take small steps, and to listen to the statistical evidence. A distributed system of criticism can tap into a larger knowledge base, and create valuable feedback through which course corrections at intermediate stages can be achieved.

The peculiar twist in India is that in many areas, the statistical system is weak. We are down to gathering anecdotal evidence by talking to people. No one individual can talk with a large number of people.

Each critic is valuable insofar as she represents information from a different subset of the system under examination. Critics of public policy strategies are a valuable part of society, and essential for the process of crossing the river by feeling the stones. The critic is not a bad human being; the critic is not an enemy; he is someone who has given you free advice that helps strengthen your work.

> *We must love them both, those whose opinions we share and those whose opinions we reject, for both have labored in the search for truth, and both have helped us in finding it.*
>
> St. Thomas Aquinas

We need not agree with our critics, but our critics can help us see the flaws in our thinking and make improvements. We should not attack critics, and